

| By Saurabh Shukla |

They call him the Twitter Minister and he's certainly got South Block and foreign policy wonks all atwitter. Ever since the suave Shashi Tharoor brought his Oxbridge accent and overcharged Blackberry to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), he's kicked up one storm after another, so much so that the knives are clearly out in what seems to be a clash of civilisations. One, hidebound and wedded to tradition and form and diplomatic propriety, and the other, accustomed to the less restrictive and more liberal bureaucratic workings of the United Nations (UN) and high-brow literary circles. His latest faux pas, if it can be called that, involving certain remarks deemed critical on Jawaharlal Nehru's foreign policy, has revived the never-ending Tharoor saga and provided more fodder for the country's foreign policy establishment and at diplomatic soirees where his every move and twitter is greeted with malicious glee and his political obituary gets written and rewritten. This time, however, Tharoor went on the offensive, slamming the media for having quoted him out of context, "India deserves better, and, frankly, so do I," was his caustic comment.

Unfortunately for Tharoor, having stepped on so many toes and ruffled the wrong feathers, the controversies never seem to end. One reason is that he has been parachuted to a ministerial berth even though he is a first-time MP. The second is, of course, his posh accent and five-star lifestyle, and then there is the fact that the NRI and author managed to get the Congress nomination from Thiruvananthapuram in Kerala, causing much heartburn among local Congress leaders. He was brought in as a junior minister straight from a corporate job, as the chairman of a Dubai-based Afras, after his stint in the UN, which included a failed bid as India's candidate for the post of the UN secretary-general in 2007. When he first arrived at the South Block, he brought a breath of fresh air with talk of a progressive agenda and innovative

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Despite impeccable credentials, Shashi Tharoor creates his own storms with an indiscreet style



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